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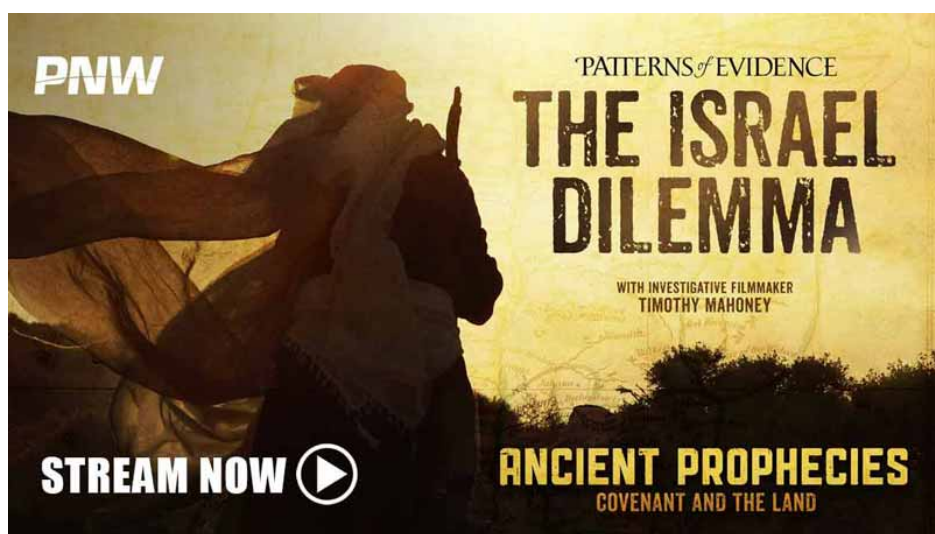
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ARTICLE

Nothing New Under The Sun: Burning Man And The Return Of Ancient Spirituality





BY PNW STAFF SEPTEMBER 02, 2026

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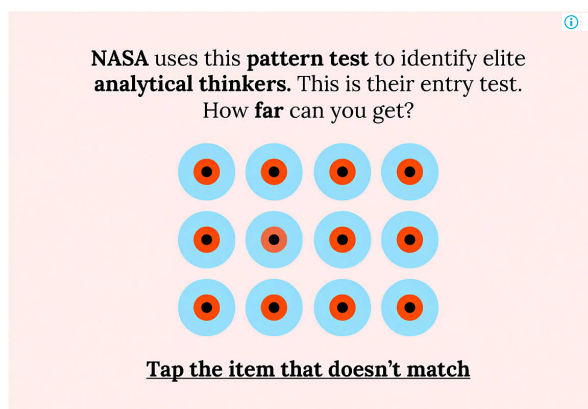
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Right now, tens of thousands of people are gathered in Nevada's Black Rock Desert for one of the strangest cultural events in America.

For one week, an empty stretch of desert becomes Black Rock City. Massive art installations rise from the dust as people wander through the desert in elaborate costumes, music continues deep into the night, and participants pursue everything from artistic expression and community to spiritual experiences and personal transformation. Eventually, enormous crowds will gather around a towering wooden figure known simply as "the Man" and watch as it is consumed by fire.

To much of the world, Burning Man is simply an eccentric celebration of art, freedom and radical self-expression. But perhaps Burning Man tells us something much deeper about modern Western civilization.

For decades we have been told that humanity is becoming increasingly secular. Traditional religion is supposedly fading because modern people have outgrown ancient beliefs, rituals and ideas about the sacred. Yet look at what is happening in the Nevada desert. Modern man may be abandoning Christianity, but he has certainly not abandoned his search for transcendence.



The Religion Of The Self

Burning Man began modestly in 1986 when a small group gathered on Baker Beach in San Francisco and burned an eight-foot wooden figure. By 1990, the gathering had migrated to Nevada, eventually becoming the enormous temporary city that exists today.

Burning Man is not officially a religion, nor should it be falsely characterized as one. Yet many of the impulses surrounding it are unmistakably spiritual.

There is ritual, sacred-like space, communal experience, fire, symbolism, transformation and a search for something beyond ordinary existence.

At the center of Burning Man's philosophy is also an idea thoroughly compatible with our modern age: the elevation of the individual self. Two of Burning Man's famous principles are "Radical Self-expression" and "Radical Self-reliance."

Contrast that with the message of Christianity. Jesus did not tell His followers to discover themselves, but to deny themselves: "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me."

Our civilization increasingly tells us that identity comes from within. We determine who we are, define our own truth and pursue whatever brings fulfillment, until authenticity to ourselves becomes one of the highest virtues.

Scripture points in the opposite direction. Our identity begins with our Creator, and true freedom is found not by enthroning ourselves but by submitting ourselves to Him.

This struggle isn't remotely new. It reaches all the way back to Genesis, where the serpent's temptation was ultimately an invitation for humanity to step outside God's authority and determine good and evil for itself. The setting changes, but the rebellion remains remarkably familiar.



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Ancient Spirituality In Modern Clothing

When Christians hear the word "paganism," they may picture ancient temples, carved idols and primitive civilizations gathered around fires. But why would pagan spirituality in the 21st century necessarily look like pagan spirituality from thousands of years ago?

Today it might involve electronic music, psychedelic experiences, sexual liberation, environmental spirituality, meditation, technology and elaborate interactive art. The outward appearance changes dramatically while many of the underlying spiritual impulses remain the same.

That makes this year's Burning Man particularly fascinating.

The 2026 theme is "Axis Mundi," an ancient concept referring broadly to a symbolic connection between heaven and earth. Burning Man's organizers describe the theme in terms of interconnectedness, shared realities and humanity's relationship with the natural world.

There is also this year's Temple of the Moon. Inspired partly by lunar cycles, the structure incorporates themes of life, death, remembrance and release. Participants use Burning Man's Temple as a deeply emotional space, leaving photographs, messages and memorials before the structure itself is eventually burned.

Think about the cultural contradiction. Western civilization supposedly moved beyond temples, sacred spaces, cosmic symbolism and religious ritual, yet thousands travel into a desert where they construct a Temple of the Moon beneath a theme called Axis Mundi, contemplate life and death, seek transformative experiences and ultimately watch enormous symbolic structures disappear into flames.

Solomon's words seem remarkably appropriate: "There is no new thing under the sun."

We Haven't Stopped Worshipping

Burning Man is only one manifestation of something much larger happening across Western society. Astrology is booming, tarot cards have returned to mainstream stores, and crystals, manifestation, witchcraft, psychedelics, goddess spirituality and various combinations of Eastern mysticism and New Age spirituality have all found receptive audiences.

Even some of the world's most technologically sophisticated people have been fascinated by Burning Man. Silicon Valley entrepreneurs and technology executives have attended the gathering over the years, and there is something deeply revealing about that. The very people helping build humanity's technological future are still searching for transcendence.

Artificial intelligence can answer questions, virtual reality can create worlds and technology can connect billions of people, but none of it can answer mankind's oldest questions: Why am I here? Who am I? What happens when I die? Is there something beyond myself?

Human beings were created with an awareness that there is more to existence than material things. Removing Christianity from a culture doesn't remove that hunger; it simply creates a vacuum waiting to be filled by something else.

Romans 1 describes humanity exchanging "the truth of God for a lie" and worshipping the creation rather than the Creator. That is the danger of a post-Christian culture. It does not necessarily become a culture without spirituality. Instead, it can become a culture filled with every spirituality except the truth.

Babel In The Desert

There is even something faintly reminiscent of Babel in what rises each year from Black Rock Desert. Thousands gather together in an empty landscape and construct an extraordinary temporary civilization where creativity, technology and human ingenuity combine to produce something genuinely impressive.

Burning Man is not literally Babel, of course, but Babel represents an enduring human temptation: mankind gathering together to establish meaning, identity and greatness apart from God. In that sense, Babel never really disappeared. Humanity simply keeps rebuilding it.

And that may be the most important lesson Christians should take from Burning Man.

The people gathering in Nevada are not simply objects of ridicule or condemnation. Many are searching for community, meaning, belonging and transcendence -- things human beings have always desired. The tragedy is that so many in our increasingly post-Christian culture are searching everywhere except the One who created them.

The desert lights, electronic music, technology and spectacular artwork may all be thoroughly modern, but mankind's desire to find meaning, identity and transcendence apart from God is ancient.

Burning Man may look like one of the most modern gatherings imaginable, but spiritually there truly is nothing new under the sun.

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